Simon Aquino

Principal Platform Engineer · Kubernetes, Terraform & Landing Zones · AWS / GCP

London, United Kingdom (open to relocation)

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Profile

Senior platform engineer (Terraform, Kubernetes, Python) with 16+ years across financial services, government, and high-growth technology. Designs and builds Internal Developer Platforms and the Kubernetes, landing-zone, and GitOps foundations beneath them, as shared, self-service capability that lets application teams deploy and operate independently.

- **IDP Architecture:** Defined the architecture for a greenfield Internal Developer Platform at Barclays (AWS/EKS) that cut team onboarding from weeks to minutes, and drove "Golden Path" platform strategy at JPMorgan Chase, preserving team autonomy.
- **Kubernetes & Landing Zones:** Led the firm-wide GCP landing zones initiative at JPMorgan Chase, now running globally, and set technical direction for a firm-wide GCP and Kubernetes ecosystem of 100+ clusters, delivered within ISO 27001/SOC 2-aligned frameworks; AKS at Haleon, GKE at Loveholidays and eBay.
- **Identity & Access Governance:** Delivered the Haleon IAM governance platform, replacing manual audit processes with automated SOX compliance reporting on access controls (PA-02/AM-02).
- **IaC, GitOps & Observability:** Terraform Cloud, Helm, and GitHub Actions at Haleon; Terraform on AWS at Element Insurance; Crossplane and ArgoCD GitOps with Prometheus/Grafana across 100+ clusters at JPMorgan Chase.
- **AI-Assisted Engineering:** Led team adoption of GitHub Copilot and Claude Code with quality gates (AI code review backed by automated tests, plus human review): a production AKS platform in about six weeks against a typical 6–12 months.
- **Team Leadership:** Led teams of up to 13 while staying hands-on.

Professional Experience

Haleon (GSK Consumer Healthcare)

London, UK

Engineering Manager, Data & Platform Engineering — *Apr 2025 – Sep 2025, Mar 2026 – Present (rehired)*

- **Built:** Production Azure/AKS platform and CI/CD foundation (Terraform Cloud, Helm, GitHub Actions), delivered in about six weeks against a typical 6–12 months, running a greenfield Dagster/Python Medallion (Bronze/Silver/Gold) ETL pipeline (ADLS Gen2, PostgreSQL).
- **Outcome:** Delivered a greenfield data platform for Identity & Access Management (IAM) governance, replacing manual audit processes with automated SOX compliance reporting (PA-02/AM-02 controls), in iterative releases aligned to audit timelines.
- **Migrated:** Moved a team working on a SAP ERP platform from Azure DevOps to GitHub, covering source control and CI/CD.
- **AI-Assisted Engineering:** Led the team's adoption of GitHub Copilot and Claude Code, with custom team skills and AI code review backed by automated tests.
- **Team:** Built and led a new team from zero to 6 engineers, hiring them and line-managing the team (employees and contractors) through 1:1 coaching, performance feedback, and career development; managed the project budget.

Barclays

London, UK

Principal Platform Consultant — *Oct 2025 – Mar 2026*

- **Designed:** Acted as Technical Authority within the platform team, architecting the greenfield Internal Developer Platform (IDP) for the Payments division on AWS/EKS, and designing and implementing "Golden Path" patterns and automated compliance frameworks (Go, Terraform, Crossplane, Flux, Helm, GitHub Actions).
- **Outcome:** Cut team onboarding from weeks to minutes and moved legacy systems onto a secure, self-service platform.
- **Reliability:** Architected the platform on AWS/EKS for payment rails with low-latency, high-availability requirements.
- **Team:** Led the transformation of a legacy software unit into cloud-native platform engineers through hands-on pair programming, mentoring the internal Tech Lead on platform strategy, team structure, and engineering best practices.

JPMorgan Chase

London, UK

Engineering Manager, Cloud Enablement — *Apr 2023 – Mar 2025*

- **Built:** Led the firm-wide GCP landing zones initiative (self-service, isolated environments per team, including vCluster-based multi-tenancy), now running globally, and as the most senior lead in the Platform team set technical direction for the firm-wide GCP and Kubernetes ecosystem (100+ clusters), delivered within ISO 27001/SOC 2-aligned frameworks.
- **Crossplane & GitOps:** Introduced Crossplane for Infrastructure as Code (working with Upbound's engineering team on upstream improvements) and GitOps with ArgoCD, reducing deployment friction for thousands of internal developers.
- **Golden Path:** Drove a "Golden Path" platform strategy, with observability via Prometheus/Grafana, improving reliability and developer experience across teams.
- **Reliability Practices:** Set SLOs and on-call and incident practices for the platform team; ran postmortems.
- **FinOps:** Embedded FinOps as a core platform capability, giving teams cost visibility and advising senior stakeholders on cloud spend.

- **AI Enablement:** Delivered AI-ready platform blueprints (Vertex AI integration, data pipelines) on the firm-wide GCP and Kubernetes foundation, enabling teams' transition to data-intensive GenAI workloads.
- **Team:** Grew the platform team to 13 engineers, hiring around 10 including senior and lead roles, while staying hands-on.

Deloitte *Copenhagen, Denmark*

Infrastructure DevOps Lead *Mar 2021 – Mar 2023*

- **Built:** Replaced brittle custom authentication with managed AWS API Gateway, establishing a standardised, secure pattern for external integrations.
- **Outcome:** Consolidated infrastructure, simplifying legacy complexity and reducing monthly cloud operational costs without compromising system performance.
- **Team:** Led the AWS cloud infrastructure stream for Denmark's Property Tax Platform, coordinating across 3 satellite teams in Denmark and the US to resolve cross-functional architectural blockers.

Microsoft (for Refinitiv) *London, UK*

Principal Consultant *Nov 2020 – Mar 2021*

- **Migration Delivery:** Served in Microsoft's Professional Services, consulting within the team migrating one of Refinitiv's trading applications from on-prem to Azure, optimising AKS/EventHubs for high-frequency throughput.
- **Environment Delivery:** Led the delivery of the first full development environment, acting as liaison between internal teams and Microsoft.
- **Architecture:** Took part in architecture meetings to define project scope, develop a proof of concept, and tackle key technical challenges.

Selected earlier roles

- Mar 2020 – Oct 2020, **Loveholidays, Lead Platform Engineer:** Resolved latency bottlenecks in Go/Java microservices on GKE, achieving 30% performance gains through Kubernetes autoscaling optimisation.
- Jun 2019 – Mar 2020, **eBay, Lead DevOps Engineer:** Orchestrated the migration of eBay Classifieds to GCP, architecting standardised GKE workflows, Istio service mesh and custom Kubernetes operators for distributed European engineering teams.
- Mar 2017 – Feb 2018, **Element Insurance, Senior DevOps Engineer:** Built and managed AWS infrastructure (EC2, S3, Lambda, CloudWatch, DynamoDB) with Terraform.
- Feb 2016 – Feb 2017, **HMRC, Senior DevOps Consultant:** UK Government digital tax at scale.
- Aug 2015 – Feb 2016, **KPMG, DevOps Engineer:** Designed and built multi-tenant AWS infrastructure to deploy the Hortonworks Data Platform for KPMG clients, including data security and infrastructure hardening.
- 2010 – 2011, **Google, Corporate Operations Engineer (intern):** Python/App Engine internal tooling (20% project); Python Readability award (internal code quality).

Skills

Cloud & Platform	AWS, GCP (Pro Architect), Azure, Kubernetes (EKS, AKS, GKE), Internal Developer Platforms (IDP), Developer Experience (DevEx), Platform-as-a-Product, Landing Zones, Infrastructure as Code (Terraform), Helm, Crossplane, ArgoCD, Flux, GitHub Actions, CI/CD.
Ops, Security & Data	SRE Practices, Prometheus, Grafana, DevSecOps, Zero Trust, Identity Governance & IAM, SOX Controls, Data Pipelines (ETL/Medallion), Dagster, PostgreSQL.
Architecture & Dev	Go, Python, Distributed Systems, Event-Driven Architecture, Microservices, API Design.
AI-Assisted Delivery	GitHub Copilot, Claude Code, custom team skills, AI code review backed by automated tests.
Leadership & Strategy	Team Building & Scaling, Org Design, Tech Recruitment, Coaching & Career Development, Executive Stakeholder Management, Engineering Strategy, Remote/Distributed Leadership, Project Budgeting, FinOps.
Languages	English and Italian (native), German (B2), Danish (A2).

Education

University of Bristol *Bristol, UK*

Master of Engineering (MEng) Hons in Computer Science and Electronics *2012*

Certificates

2025 **Google Cloud Platform (GCP),** Professional Cloud Architect (PCA)

2025 **Google Cloud Platform (GCP),** Generative AI Leader

2014 **Red Hat,** Red Hat Certified System Administrator (RHCSA)